

To: Utah State Department of Education
Regarding: Concerns About School Culture, Administrative Practices, and Financial Transparency

Dear State Oversight Representative,

I am writing anonymously because I am deeply concerned about the culture that has developed within our school and its effect on teachers and staff. I am directing these concerns specifically toward the leadership of Director Justin Blasko. The administrative structure has become so complex and layered that it feels less like an open system of collaboration and more like a barrier controlling access, information, and communication.

I am choosing anonymity because the current culture has made speaking openly feel professionally unsafe.

Teachers enter this profession to help children learn, grow, and discover what they are capable of becoming. We build students up, encourage them through mistakes, and teach them that their worth is not determined by a score or single performance. Yet many staff members work within a system that does not extend those same principles to educators.

There is a persistent feeling that we are not good enough.

Teachers feel pressure to continually prove their value and perform at an exceptional level simply to feel secure in their positions. There is a sense that we are always being evaluated, easily replaceable, and expected to provide extraordinary effort without meaningful recognition.

At the same time, teachers are carrying an increasing number of programs, initiatives, assessments, meetings, documentation requirements, and changing procedures. Individually, many may serve reasonable purposes. Collectively, however, they have created an environment in which dedicated educators feel overwhelmed rather than supported.

One example is the treatment of employee leave. Staff members receive a yearly allotment of paid leave, yet nearly 50 blackout days have reportedly been established during which employees are strongly discouraged or restricted from using it. Employees also cannot access paid-leave days until they earn them month by month. This contributes to the perception that even employment benefits carry an expectation that teachers demonstrate commitment by not using them.

More troubling is what happens when concerns are raised.

Staff are encouraged to ask questions, provide feedback, and challenge ideas, but there is a growing perception that doing so can carry professional consequences. Employees have witnessed situations in which questioning administrative decisions or pushing back against a

system has resulted in serious administrative action, pressure to resign, or continued “monitoring” without clear expectations, specific suggestions, or meaningful support.

There is also concern that staff members are watched, monitored, or observed by administrators who then report information to Director Blasko. In some cases, it appears that the director makes judgments based on these reports without personally observing the circumstances. Whether every report is accurate or not, the perception of surveillance creates an atmosphere of fear rather than trust.

When employees believe that respectfully disagreeing, questioning a decision, or expressing concern could jeopardize their professional standing, genuine collaboration cannot exist. People become quiet, stop asking questions, second-guess their words, and learn that silence may be safer.

This is also why anonymous surveys may fail to reflect the severity of the situation. Employees may fear that responses could be traced through identifying details, writing style, timing, access to survey data, follow-up questions, or informal reporting. They may soften their language, omit examples, or avoid participating altogether.

If staff input is sought, it should be collected and analyzed by an independent outside entity with clear safeguards against identification or retaliation. Employees need to know who will access responses, how anonymity will be protected, and whether administrators will be prevented from attempting to identify respondents.

There is also a troubling disconnect between the language of support and employees’ lived experience. Concerns raised in good faith can feel misunderstood, reframed, or attributed to intentions the employee did not have. This has left me and other employees questioning whether meaningful communication with leadership is possible.

Policies and expectations can also feel inconsistent, with changing interpretations or exceptions that make it difficult for employees to know what is expected. When expectations are unclear but consequences feel significant, uncertainty becomes a source of anxiety.

The administrative structure surrounding Director Blasko contributes to this problem. Information appears to move through multiple layers of administrators, supervisors, and intermediaries before reaching or coming from the director. Staff may not know who is making decisions, what information is being relied upon, how concerns are being interpreted, or whether the director has direct knowledge of the circumstances. Instead of creating transparency and accountability, this structure can function as a barrier between leadership and employees.

Our school’s recent academic reading success should bring tremendous pride. Reaching the top levels of performance in the state reflects enormous work by students, teachers, support staff, families, and leadership. Yet when that success is discussed in a staff meeting as “legislators are calling me to ask what the school is doing,” or when staff hear “they know who we are,” it

can leave employees wondering whether recognition and institutional prominence have begun to overshadow the people doing the daily work—and the students whose efforts made that success possible.

School achievement should never come at the expense of the educators responsible for creating it. At Vista School, many excellent educators have left because the emotional cost became too great to continue working within a system they felt did not hear them or provide safety.

There are also serious concerns about the school's finances and the explanations given for denying needed resources. Staff members are frequently told that requests cannot be approved because "we don't have the funding" or because the cost cannot be justified. At the same time, it has reportedly been stated that the school has approximately \$13 million in excess or reserve funds, due in part to responsible financial management.

I believe there should be independent oversight of school funds so that questions about pay discrepancies and financial concerns can be addressed without fear. There also needs to be greater transparency regarding how funds are spent. The financial officer, Mr. Troy Bradshaw, appears to have substantial control over the entirety of the school's financial affairs.

If the school has millions of dollars in reserve, staff and the public need a clear explanation of how those funds are designated, what restrictions apply, and why essential needs continue to be denied. It is difficult to reconcile reports of approximately \$13 million in excess funds with very large class sizes and claims that there is not enough money to hire additional staff or address other pressing needs.

This raises important questions:

- How much money is currently held in reserves or excess funds?
- What is the purpose of those funds?
- Are they legally or contractually restricted?
- What criteria determine whether an expense can be justified?
- Why are class sizes so large if substantial funds are available?
- Are financial decisions made consistently and transparently?
- Are employees and the public receiving accurate and complete information about the school's financial position?

These questions are requests for transparency and accountability. When employees are told that resources are unavailable while substantial reserves reportedly exist, trust is damaged unless leadership provides a clear, documented explanation.

There is a difference between high expectations and a culture of fear. There is a difference between accountability and making employees feel perpetually inadequate. There is a

difference between encouraging excellence and creating the belief that extraordinary effort is simply the minimum required to remain employed.

Teachers are asked every day to create classrooms based on belonging, emotional safety, growth, respect, and human dignity. Some of those same teachers do not experience those conditions in their own workplace.

Many of us continue coming to school because we love our students. We prepare lessons, solve problems, communicate with families, support struggling children, celebrate growth, and give far beyond what can be captured in a job description. Dedication to children should not require educators to surrender their dignity or well-being.

I respectfully ask that the appropriate state entity independently examine:

- Staff climate and psychological safety;
 - Employee leave practices and blackout dates;
 - Disciplinary and administrative-leave procedures;
 - The consistency and transparency of school policies;
 - Whether staff are monitored or reported on without adequate context;
 - Whether administrative decisions rely on direct observation or secondhand reports;
 - Employee retention, turnover, and absenteeism;
 - Whether staff can raise concerns without fear of retaliation;
 - The independence and confidentiality of employee surveys;
 - The school's reserve and excess funds;
 - The reasons given for denying staffing and resource requests;
 - Class sizes and whether available funds are addressing student and staff needs;
- and
- The administrative structure and decision-making process under Director Justin Blasko.

Any review should include confidential interviews with current and former employees conducted by individuals independent of school administration. Employees should not be required to report concerns through the same structure they are concerned about.

Please do not rely solely on anonymous surveys administered or controlled by the school. Even surveys described as anonymous may not reveal the true severity of the situation when employees fear their responses could be traced. A meaningful review must allow staff to speak privately, independently, and without fear that their comments will be reported to or interpreted by the director or other administrators.

Please listen not only to leadership's description of the culture, but most importantly to the people living within it every day.

There are exceptional educators here at Vista School. They care deeply about children and have worked extraordinarily hard to help this school succeed. They should not have to choose between protecting their professional security and speaking honestly about conditions that are hurting them.

Teachers spend their careers helping children understand that mistakes are opportunities for growth, that their voices matter, and that their worth is greater than their performance.

We are asking for the same humanity to be extended to us.

Respectfully,

A Concerned Educator